LESSON 3: FOUNDATIONS OF CURRICULUM

3.1 Introduction

Welcome to our third lesson. In this lesson we shall learn about foundations of curriculum. These pillars are the foundations of curriculum. When developing curriculum, experts dwell and draw much of the knowledge and principles on the existing pillars. These pillars are the factors which provide background information on which the curriculum developers depend on to make the decisions. Curriculum foundation refers to the factors that influence the minds of curriculum developers to make decisions on what to be included in the curriculum and its structure. There are certain factors which provide background information on which the curriculum developers depend to make the decisions. Foundations of curriculum can also be viewed as the considerations of educational programs and policies in the light of an interdisciplinary endeavor. They are historical foundations, philosophical foundations, psychological foundation and sociological and cultural foundation. In this lesson we shall see how curriculum making is influenced by these foundations. Welcome to the lesson.

3.2 Lesson learning outcomes

By the end of this first lesson, you should be able to:

3.2.1 Explain the influence of history on curriculum making

3.2.2 Differentiate between the various philosophies and their influence on curriculum

3.2.3 Explain the role of psychology on the learning process and curriculum design

3.2.4 Describe the role of sociology in curriculum making

3.2.1 Historical foundations of curriculum

Historical foundations of curriculum are factors and issues from the past that influence curriculum at present. For instance, the nature of the present curriculum in any school system of education is influenced by the nature of the curriculum in the past. These refer to those influences on the curriculum that are derived from developments in the past. They form the basis for decision making and systematic growth of the education system.

Relevant aspects in discerning the Historical Foundations of Curriculum include the following:

i. Early Christian Education
ii. The Renaissance
iii. The Reformation
iv. The scientific movement
v. The progressive Education Movement

Early Christian Education

The values of early Christian education were a blend of Greek, Roman and Hebrew ideals. The early Christian schools taught the liberal arts and also concerned themselves with inducting new believers into church membership. The Curriculum of the early Christian schools comprised the teaching of discipline, church, doctrine, moral standards, Christian theology, science, mathematics and astronomy.

ii. The Renaissance

Following increased quest for knowledge and thirst for adventure 'humanistic schools' were established. The curriculum of the 'humanistic schools' emphasized the study of man as a prerequisite to understanding man's role and contribution to society. Humanistic schools received inspiration from traditions in the Roman grammar schools.

The curriculum in 'humanistic schools' included good manners, morals, rhetoric composition, sports, games and dance. Due to increased degree of enlightment during the renaissance period, there arose a need for people with certain vocational skills related to international and national trade. As a result the curriculum of the school started to have an increasing amount of vocational studies in the form of book-keeping, business arithmetic, general correspondence and the keeping of committee minutes and records. The height of the Renaissance saw the development of the university in response to the need for a higher cadre of professional people with special faculty specializations. The university then developed faculties to cater for Studies in liberal arts, Law studies, Medicine and Theology.

iii. The Scientific movement

The campaigns of Martin Luther, led to the publication of biblical and other materials in the vernaculars so that every person should read for themselves and independently interpret the bible.

The humanistic curriculum was enriched with the study of science, mathematics, history and gymnastics. Ignatius of Loyola developed an expanded and advanced curriculum as a counter movement to the reformation in Jesuit schools. The reformation contributed further to educational growth by inciting the church into greater activity in elementary, secondary and higher education.

iv. The Scientific Movement in Education

Educators and philosophers of the sixteenth century were concerned more with observation regarding the working of the universes. This was led by Francis Bacon among others. It led to the philosophy of realism which has three district phases, with various implications of the curriculum. These are Humanistic Realism which advocated student mastery of form and content of the old literature as a basis for improving the present world. Social Realism that aimed at meeting the purposes of the contemporary world; It was class conscious as a result it advocated an elicit education for the aristocracy, emphasized private tuition in the home, using paid tutors and aimed at producing a polished gentleman of high society. The Sense Realism which was concerned with problems of the current real world and emphasis on an instructional approach based on sense perception.

v. The Progressive movement in Education

The advocates of the progressive movement were reacting against the shortcomings in the traditional school system. The argued that the curriculum content of the traditional system included a great deal of meaningless and needles content, that the traditional curriculum did not give utility education. It mainly emphasized academics. The traditional methods of teaching introduced the child to subject matter of no practical value and the traditional curriculum was rigid and did not cater for the individual needs of particular students.

The progressive education curriculum instead emphasized five approaches to the teaching/learning process which are:

i) Teacher- pupils planning of curricular activities
ii) Flexible curriculum and individualized instruction
iii) Non-formal curriculum activities and physical training in areas such as games and related hobbies.

iv) Learner centered methodology

v) Selection of study material in line with expressed interests and concerns of the learner.

All these allowed children maximum self-direction and reduced teacher domination of the teaching/learning process.

In summary,

History will tell the curriculum planner how to develop and modify the curriculum, with the experiences of the past, what to teach and what should be the core material of the subjects, what objectives they want to achieve through the curriculum. The history of the curriculum also explains the teacher psychology at different times in history and how to improve their teaching styles. The history also provides a detail about the learner behavior at different times in history. It also provides information about the psychology of the students, how they learn and what they want to learn. In times curriculum changed its shapes and patterns from teacher center curriculum to learner center curriculum due to the long history of the curriculum development process from Plato to modern curriculum. The history of the curriculum also changed the teaching methods, now every researcher are finding new ways to teach and it is also becoming the part of curriculum an history.

3.2.2 Philosophical foundation curriculum

Philosophical or value foundations constitute the values and beliefs that make up the philosophies of life and of education and have a permeating influence on the other foundations. Statements of educational philosophy point to methodical efforts by philosophers to examine values in society, derive meanings from facts, organize experiences in a manner useful to educational practitioners and the pupils in the school system, justify one or some educational beliefs over others. Develop new proposals of educational practice for translation into action.

In utilizing knowledge of philosophy in curriculum, the curriculum planner is seeking to establish ideas and notions that will indicate a priority of values in selecting experiences for the curriculum. The value or philosophical orientations which the educational system is charged with promoting form an integral part of the culture of a nation.

Curriculum development has been influenced by a number of philosophical schools which include traditional school represented by Perennialism and Essentialism, the progressivists and theromanticism, these schools have advanced three theories of subject matter as shown below.

The perennialists

Perennialism values knowledge that transcends time. This is a subject-centered philosophy. The goal of a perennialist educator is to teach students to think rationally and develop minds that can think critically. A perennialist classroom aims to be a closely organized and well-disciplined environment, which develops in students a lifelong quest for the truth. Perennialists believe that education should epitomize a prepared effort to make these ideas available to students and to guide their thought processes toward the understanding and appreciation of the great works; works of literature written by history's finest thinkers that transcend time and never become outdated. Perennialists are primarily concerned with the importance of mastery of the content and development of reasoning skills. The adage "the more things change, the more they stay the same" summarizes the perennialists' perspective on education. In this philosophy skills are developed in a sequential manner. Here, the teachers are the main actors on the stage

The Essentialists

To the essentialists subject matter should be taught for use. They maintain that there are certain essentials that each student in school ought to know. The essentialists devote their time to, e-examining curricula matters, distinguishing the essential and the non-essentials in school programmes and re-establishing the authority of the teacher in the classroom. to the essentialists and perennialists agree on certain fundamental principles such as that learning involves hard work often couple with unwilling application, that the teacher's role is to mediate between the adult world and the world of the child, that the heart of the educational process is the assimilation of prescribed subject matter and lastly that the school should retain traditional methods of mental discipline.

The Progressivists

They believed that subject matter is a medium for teaching life processes and skills. They take the pragmatist view that change, is the essence of reality. Educators must be ready to modify methods and policies in light of new knowledge and changes in the environment. To progressivists, a good

school is not a place of compulsory instruction but a community of old and young engaged in learning by co-operative experience.

Progressivists' principles are that education should be life itself not a preparation for living, that learning should be directly related to the interests of the child, that learning through problem solving should take precedence over the inculcating of subject matter. That teachers have to advise not direct pupils and that the school should encourage co-operation as opposed to competition.

Romanticism

Romantics believed in the natural goodness of humans which is hindered by the urban life of civilization. Romanticism was a philosophical movement during the Age of Enlightenment (roughly 18th century) which emphasizes emotional self-awareness as a necessary pre-condition to improving society and bettering the human condition. Romantics believed that knowledge is gained through intuition rather than deduction. This is a student-centered philosophy that focuses on differentiation - meeting the students learning readiness needs. At a school founded on the philosophy of romanticism there is no set curricula, no formal classes and tests. Students decide what they want to learn and, in some cases, the students are expected to take the full responsibility of their learning. Sometimes meetings are set-up with professionals of a field to give them insight to that topic. The five essential characteristics of romanticism are imagination, intuition, individuality, idealism, and inspiration. Some proponents of romanticism are Jean-Jacques Rousseau and Maria Montessori.

In summary

Philosophy involves an inquiry into the nature and meaning of life including ideas about the nature of human beings, social values and purpose of education. One's perception of Philosophy largely influences one's view of learners and of various learning activities.

The philosophical foundation of curriculum helps determine the driving purpose of education, as well as the roles of the various participants. While all foundations propose to set goals of curriculum, philosophy presents the manner of thinking from which those goals are created. Curriculum makers, must have espoused a philosophy or philosophies deemed necessary for planning, implementing, and evaluating a school curriculum.

The philosophy that the curriculum makers have embraced will help them achieve the following:

1. define the school's purpose
2. identify the essential subjects to be taught

3. design the kind of learning students must have
4. develop approaches or methodologies on how students can acquire the necessary knowledge, skills, and attitude
5. produce the instructional materials
6. identify the methods and strategies to be used, and
7. determine how teachers will evaluate students.

Likewise, philosophy offers solutions to problems by helping the administrators, curriculum planners, and teachers make sound decisions. A person's philosophy reflects his/her life experiences, social and economic background, shared beliefs, and education.

3.2.3 Psychological foundation of curriculum

Curriculum is influenced by psychology in that psychology play a vital role in the teaching learning process it is the foundation for all type of educational related programmed. Psychology provides information about the teaching and learning process. These are insights gained from psychology which have a bearing on the learning process. Psychologists believe that learning experiences have to be introduced to the learner when such exposure is most effective and most beneficial to him. It could be stated that psychology influence curriculum making it its learning theories. Psychology also contributes to formulation of appropriate educational goals and decisions regarding the scope of curriculum

Psychological foundation is based on the individual differences, every student has its own unique personality and they have differences in their leering and skills. They are different in nature so they can't be treated alike in teaching learning process, some may be fast learner while other slow. Therefore the curriculum should be based on the above facts, and it should be design to support the capacity and potentialities of all the students.

Psychology play a vital role in the teaching learning process it is the foundation for all type of educational related programmed. The methods of teaching, the selection of content of subjects, the methods and theories of learning, the overall development of the students and to inculcate the

norms of the society in the students. Psychology helps in all the processes above in the development process of the curriculum. In the past curriculum for child development and learning was developed in traditional ways without keeping in view the psychological implication in the development of curriculum.

Today psychology is the core and foundation element of all the learning processes; curriculum development, child mental development, teaching methods, learning theories, administration of education system and planning, character building of the students, attitude of students and teacher, the society, the use of different technologies.

Today the researchers and scholars using experimental approach to find new ways of teaching learning process, how students learn under different conditions. They are finding new ways and materials from the analysis of teaching learning problem and formulating new approaches for teaching and learning process.

In the process of using psychology in curriculum development process some positive concepts or ideas about teaching learning process emerged, it is reflected in the work produced by different authors.

The traditional readiness concept for a difficult subject which require children maturity has been rejected by the modern researchers, now the researchers formed a new principle that the child can teach any subject on the condition that it provided keeping in view the principle of from simple to complex and that the students have the previous experience.

- When the importance is given to basic concepts and the process of inquiry for teaching learning and curriculum development process the transfer of learning and future learning are improved.
- The guided discovery of the relationships in the student learning outcomes, subject matter and in teaching methods play a very important role in the teaching learning process compare to those approaches in which the curriculum planner used the views and conclusions of other for developing curriculum.
- The Interest and motivation level of the students may be generated using the discovery method within the subject itself, the content of the subject should be interesting and appealing to generate curiosity in the students to find more. In this way the student engage in finding the relationships in the subject matter presented to him, and engage the students in the process of inquiry.

- Meaningful conversation involves the students in the organizing or structuring of facts into conceptual system which help the students to generate new ideas, make new interpretations and raise new questions.
- The researchers prefer the use of inductive methods because it helps in the discovery through inquiry and help in the formulating of hypotheses and interpretation of information.
- To study a topic in depth or more helpful in the discovering the relationships between them than try to cover the whole material in once.
- The depth of learning could be attained by applying different ideas, processes, theories, and models.
- Learning is improved when there is relationship order in the continuity of unit to unit from simple to complex in the instruction programme.
- The solving of problems helps the students in acquiring the concept development, and how to use different principles which lead the students to a higher level of mental development.
- It put emphasis on the organizing of ideas which helps the students to develop the skills to identify the relationships, improves their skills, remembers and retrieves old ideas; it provides a foundation for generating new ideas and concepts, and helps in the transfer of learning.

Therefore, it is said that the impact of psychological sources on the foundations of curriculum is more than significant and still on the rise. The scope of the psychology for applying in curriculum construction and its principles, concepts, processes. The role of psychology in the development of curriculum is vast and with each day it is becoming increasingly more meaningful and unavoidable.

Curriculum needs educational psychology to provide information particularly in four areas:

- Prepare objectives of education.
- Characteristics of the students.
- The leaning processes.
- The methods of Teaching.

3.2.4 Sociological foundation of curriculum

The social foundations encompass the systematic study of groups and institutions in the culture with reference to their contribution to the process and growth of the educational system as well as the established practices in the school system. According to Murray print (1993), the society and culture exercise massive powers on the formation curriculum and the reason behind that it was society who created schooling to safeguard the survival of their cultural heritage, and survival of their species.

The purpose of curriculum planner and developers to translate traditional norms, philosophies, ethics, knowledge and attitudes in the objectives of curriculum, the content, learning processes and the evaluation of elements of the curriculum. Sociological factors have highest impact on the content of curriculum and that is the reason that curriculum developers and planner both reflect and transfer their own culture in curriculum. Therefore a curriculum without the reflection of culture is not possible for that reason one should consider what characteristic of the culture should be the part of curriculum and what not.

In the sociological foundations, the curriculum designer is actually dealing with cultural values, societal needs and the learners' backgrounds. The institutions and forces which make up the culture and related analytical techniques determine the curriculum or programme of education schools will follow. The curriculum should be able to examine and clarify obstacles prevalent in society which make change in positive direction difficult. In designing a curriculum based on social foundation the following distinct levels should be considered

i) Purpose of the curriculum
ii) Pressure influencing the curriculum
iii) Characteristics of the students experiencing the curriculum
iv) Role and contribution of other social institutions such as the family and religious institutions.

The sociological foundation emphasizes the influence of society to education. It is founded on the belief that there is a mutual and encompassing relationship between society and curriculum because it exists within the societal context.

Any discussion of curriculum should consider the social setting and its influence on curricular decisions. A study of sociology provides, among other things, necessary clues about the characteristics of contemporary life and the future in which the learners will lead the rest of their lives. These clues help to make a curriculum socially relevant.

Social pressures influence the characteristics of students who experience the curriculum in the educational institutions which are established and maintained by society.

Students live in a world larger than the college/school and learn a great deal from experiences in that part of their lives. What a learner acquires in the college/school and outside may be complementary or conflicting to each other.

The latter case gives rise to the complaint that what is learned in college/school has little to do with the real world. But, in the former case the college/school may be a major factor in the improvement of society by helping young people to develop the capacity to respond intelligently to social problems.

In this way, the curriculum serves not only the needs of the learner, but also the needs of society. For these reasons, in developing curricular plans, we must consider the characteristics of contemporary society as well as those that are expected to emerge in the future. Of course, curriculum planning and course content basically depends on an analysis of the nature of society.

Though schools are formal institutions that educate the people, other units of society educate or influence the way people think, such as families and friends, and communities.

Since society is dynamic, many developments are difficult to cope with and adjust to.

But the schools are made to address and understand the changes not only in one's country but in the world as well.

Society is dynamic, with the changing popularity of a particular philosophy mirroring factors such as environmental and economical needs: war or peace time, recession or time of abundance, changing technology, and so on. For example, if a nation is at war, greater emphasis will be placed on sacrificing for the greater good, moralistic principles, and adhering to group norms.

Therefore, schools must be relevant by making their curriculum more innovative and interdisciplinary. A curriculum that can address global learners' diversities, the explosion of knowledge through the internet, and the educational reforms and policies.

During such times, however, there will be dissention based on counter philosophical ideas; the strength of one's philosophical convictions will determine one's perception of the current events, including those impacting education.

Society influences curriculum in the following ways:

Society and education

Most of us regard education as synonymous with schooling. But, in actual fact even a society that has no formal colleges/schools still educates its young through ceremonies, rituals, stories, observation and emulation of parents, elders, etc.

The norms of society govern interpersonal relations and produce a model personality-the attitudes, feelings and behaviour patterns most members of a society share.

It also assigns specific roles to each of its members and expects them to conform to certain established behavioural patterns.

Clearly, global aspects of human growth and development are accomplished partly by the structured curriculum in use in colleges/schools and partly by society. Does this mean that a curriculum should mirror current social forces?

A curriculum while reflecting contemporary social forces should also be able to respond to the dynamics of change. By implication, the curriculum should not only reflect society but also help to shape it.

Social change and the curriculum

Contemporary society is changing so swiftly that we have difficulty coping with it, adjusting ourselves to the present and preparing for the future.

Contrary to this fact, our colleges/schools appear to be conservative institutions that usually lag behind the change.

To make education respond to social changes, a curriculum should be framed keeping in mind, among other things, the following:

i) growth of technology;
ii) structure of the family; and
iii) cultural diversity. What we mean by each of these is discussed below:

Growth of technology

Today, the young are growing up in a world that is very different from that of a generation or two ago. Connected with this is the fact that ours is a society based on information. In addition to the creation of new kinds of jobs, this new information society will influence all the other aspects of the workplace.

At one level, such influence will motivate societies to use computers and other information-processing devices to replace manual workers, at another, the locale of the workplace will also be affected. In agricultural and industrial phases, workers have had to be brought to a central location where goods are/were produced.

Given the availability of communications technology, this kind of centralization will no longer be necessary for every activity. One can simply work at home using microcomputers. And, increased value will be placed upon persons who can network their credentials to fill the emerging needs of the information society.

Underlying all this is a serious challenge to the ethics of work that has pervaded our society and schools/colleges. Among the values the schools/colleges have promoted are those related to the productive industrial worker-punctuality, loyalty, acceptance, appearance etc.

In the decentralised information-society, workers will find themselves largely working alone, setting flexible work patterns, working hours and servicing more than one employer. Furthermore, having been replaced by new technology, many will have difficulty finding new jobs because they lack certain skills. Thus, the combination of the growth of technology and of the information society may lead to a serious review of the traditional ethics of work and its place in our society. Obviously, I curriculum will have to undergo a change in order to match with and capture social changes.

Structures of family

The family has been viewed as the basis of the complex social fabric. The picture of the family consisting of both natural parents and their children is steadily fading, replaced by a much more complicated diversity of family structures.

For example, separation, divorce and childbirth without marriage have given rise to the phenomenon of single parent homes. Geographical mobility is weakening the bonds of the centrally located, extended family of grandparents, aunts, uncles and other relatives.

Traditionally, while men used to go out to work, women managed the home. Now we find increasing number of families in which both the father and the mother work.

How does this influence educational institutions?

The school/college as we know it today evolved in the context of the traditional family structure. Mothers were expected to provide a stable and predictable environment for young people.

When children had problems in school/colleges, parents could be called upon to devote time and energy to support the values and efforts of the school/college.

Today, these expectations are no longer certain. As the structure of family has changed, so has its role and function in relation to the school/college. Traditionally our lives have been focussed on common social features of life and even conformity.

Today, however, people have begun to seek more diversity in life styles, seeking new pathways and alternative routes. Among the many institutions that are affected by the new wave of individualism and diversity is the school/college.

The reason is that schools/colleges have served as major sources for promoting common I values among youth. This new trend in life patterns and values poses serious questions in curriculum planning.

Symptoms of the breakdown in sex-role stereotypes are clearly visible in many areas of life. As women assume new roles and demonstrate excellence and ability in them, some disgust or resentment on the part of those who continue to cling to old stereotypes cannot be avoided. The changing perception and reality of sex roles and this opposition to such changes will also have a tremendous impact on curriculum development.

Cultural diversity

As we are moving away from "a melting-pot" society to a "salad bowl" one, the increasing trend away from a homogeneous culture towards one of diversity/plurality is quite conspicuous. This shift of movement can be attributed to the following phenomena: diversity in values and life-styles (*being different is now a socially sanctioned idea*); renewed interest in ethno-history (*people have developed a new interest in their own histories and personal heritage*); and development in telecommunications (*people have been reminded of their links with cultures in other parts of the world).*

Traditionally, an educational institution has been viewed as the major social agent in the "melting-pot" process. Now it is caught in an ambiguous position between its traditional role and the emerging trend towards diversity. The question as to how the curriculum should portray cultural values, then gains importance in curriculum development today.

Having reviewed the social changes and pointed to their impact on curriculum planning, we might say that the human society is, in general, in transition from an industrial to post-industrial phase of our history, though at different stages of advancement.

Identifying the general direction that the new phase will take is particularly challenging since there is no historical precedent for post-industrialism. As long as a society is dynamic, the debate over the aims of education will stir up changes. Perhaps this is good, perhaps this is what makes society viable and able to resist decay.

3.3 Assessment questions

1. In about 50 words, explain how history influence curriculum making
2. Differentiate between the various philosophies and their influence on curriculum
3. Explain the role of psychology on the learning process and curriculum design
4. Describe the role of sociology in curriculum making

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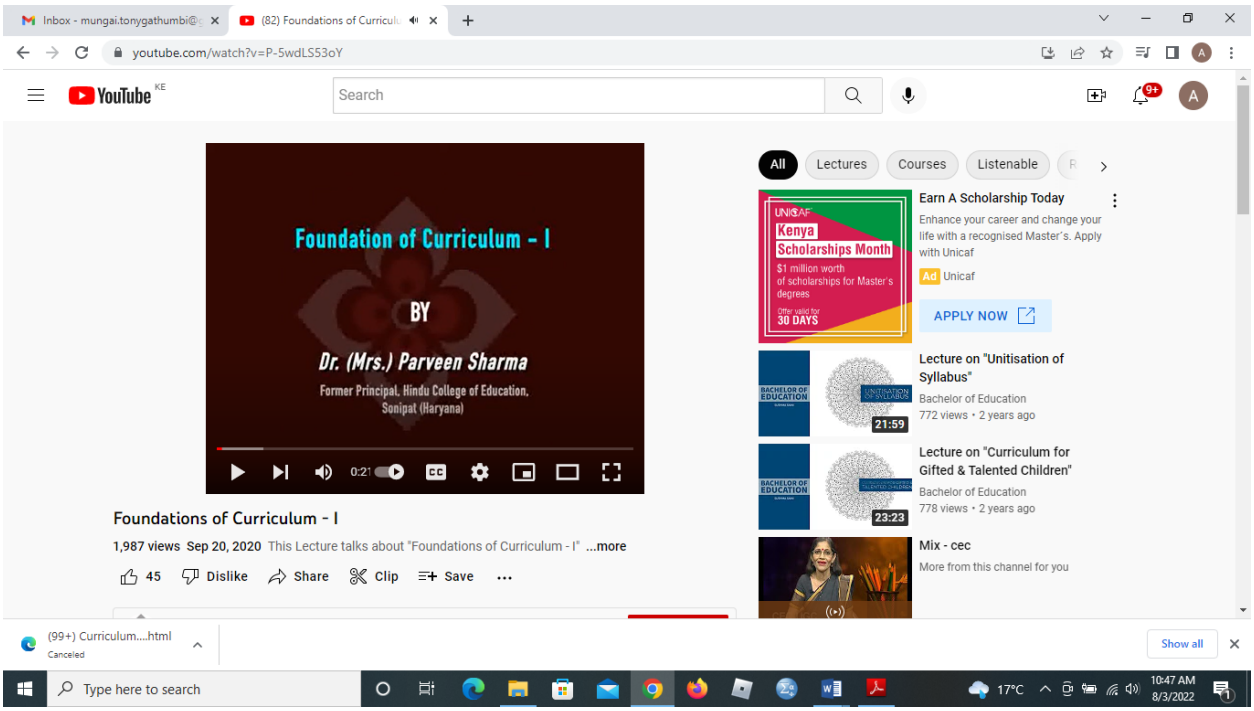
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